MODERN WESTERN INFANTRY

The ending of the Cold War confrontation with the Soviet Union in the late 1980s suggested that the forces of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) states might find themselves without an enemy to fight. Instead, the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait in 1990 provoked the US and its allies to fight the Gulf War against Iraq in 1991. Islamic terrorism and Iraqi intransigence further led to the invasions of Afghanistan in 2001 and Iraq in 2003, both headed by the US with Britain in support, and both followed by a troubled occupation. The all-volunteer infantry who fought in these conflicts were well trained and enjoyed a superb level of equipment. But their experience showed that the lot of the soldier on the ground remained as demanding as it had ever been.

US INFANTRYMAN

Since 1973, when the US withdrew from Vietnam, the US Army has been an all-volunteer force committed to equal opportunities. The presence of large numbers of women in the army (up from 2 per cent of personnel in 1973 to almost 15 per cent by 2006) marked a sharp break with the long tradition of warfare as a male preserve. Volunteers male or female primarily came from sections of US society in which other employment prospects were poor, giving the army the problem of training individuals often short on education and potentially resistant to discipline. This was partially alleviated by the imposition of higher admission standards. Recruits are given Basic Combat Training followed by Advanced Individual Training – the latter a specialist course in recognition of the technical demands imposed by modern warfare.

The Gulf War of 1991 and the invasion of Iraq in 2003 demonstrated the overwhelming effectiveness of the US Army in conventional warfare against a less well-equipped, less well-trained foe. With land, sea, and air forces coordinated under a single command, combat proceeded with relentless speed and violence, and its success provided a much-needed boost to US credibility – its competence, at least on the battlefield, had been in question since the Vietnam War. But the subsequent military occupation of Iraq and Afghanistan showed that the US could not suppress an elusive enemy armed with light but sophisticated equipment and a ruthless determination to use it. In spite of regular setbacks, the great majority of US soldiers continued to show a strong commitment to the army and to find in military service a chance to learn valuable skills and to earn a respect often denied them in civilian society.

US infantryman on patrol
A US infantryman, carrying an M16 assault rifle with grenade launcher, patrols in an armoured personnel vehicle in Iraq, 2005.

